

# THE END IS NO LONGER THE ENDGAME

The **decisive phase** of a T20 innings is shifting. Early overs are setting the tempo and often the result, leaving less for the finish to resolve.

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**M**arcus Stoinis did what finishers are meant to do. A 22-ball 62 (not out), struck at the back end, carried Punjab Kings to 222 and, for a moment, suggested control.

By the end of the night in New Chandigarh, it had counted for little. Rajasthan Royals chased the target with six wickets in hand and four balls to spare, having already taken charge in the PowerPlay. Its 84 for one in six overs outpaced Punjab's

65 for one, a difference that lingered through the chase.

Punjab had, in fact, flipped a similar script days earlier, racing to 116 without loss in the PowerPlay in a record chase of 265 against Delhi Capitals, which had managed 68 for one during the same phase.

A common thread in IPL 2026 so far has been the decisive role of the PowerPlay. That phase has influenced 77.5% of the matches this season.

"Over the years, teams have realised how important the PowerPlay is: only two fielders outside, six overs to maximise. So

naturally, there's more focus on that phase now," RR fast bowler Sandeep Sharma said.

There has been a steady rise in batters targeting boundaries in the PowerPlay, with run rates climbing from 7.7 in the inaugural season to 8.42 in 2018, and now 10.02 this season.

"What we're seeing is a trend across the tournament: how dominant teams are in the first six overs. It's very hard to stop sides now with the way they're playing in the PowerPlay. You've also got the replacement (Impact) player rule, which allows you to stack your